

shuttler P. V. Sindhu managed to reach the podium, while the Paralympics saw double that number. This trend would continue over the next two editions.

"At that point, Sachin Tendulkar reached out to us. We organised a celebration for the medallists and raised funds for not just them but also every single Indian medallist up to that point," Kamath says.

Every medallist, past and present, was given a cheque of INR 15 lakh. The contributory pool included Tendulkar himself, along with industrialists like Sanjay Ghodawat and Abhay Gadgil, sports team owners like Nimmagadda Prasad (co-owner of Kerala Blasters), and others.

Kamath suggests in jest that this kind of spotlight helped someone like Murlikant Petkar — India's first Paralympic gold medallist — finally receive his Padma Shri in 2018, 46 years after his triumph at the 1972 Games in Germany.

Avenues of change

Jhajharia had won his second gold medal in Rio but was not eligible for a Khel Ratna as per the rules at the time. However, the success of Indian athletes forced the system to take notice and make changes. Awards, felicitations, policy shifts, and the TOPS programme all came together to create a comprehensive care package for Paralympics in India.

Kamath recalls a directive from Rahul Dravid, a board member of the organisation, regarding the direction their efforts in sports needed to take.

"Rahul said there's no point in just following the herd. He suggested that we should try to bring marginalised sports and athletes into the mainstream. His idea was to focus on sports that haven't been supported, create one successful example, and look at areas like women's sports, or even extend that to disability sports.

"By doing so, you create examples that have a signalling or demonstration effect. You can change sport from the grassroots level, but you can also create a

person who becomes a catalyst for change. One person wins, and maybe 20 others think, 'If he/she can win, I can play too.' That kind of cascading change is what we're aiming for. A medal, the national anthem playing — those are wonderful moments, and they close the loop on what we're trying to achieve," he explains.

He further added, "Many of these athletes are no longer just seen as 'disabled' individuals, but as athletes competing in disability sports because their excellence is the binding factor."

This change in perspective led to more interest from the corporate world. Hyundai Motors India Foundation, the CSR arm of the car manufacturer, approached GoSports to develop a programme aimed at supporting those aspiring to be Paralympians. Hyundai has also partnered with other NGOs, such as the Samarathanam Trust for the Disabled, to support blind cricket and provide assistive devices for people with disabilities.

The PCI also saw additional support from organisations like Vedanta and the SBI Foundation. The latter, Deepa says, offered scholarships not just for elite athletes but also for B-level athletes, helping develop the second tier of talent.

Building blocks

All these conversations occupy the tip of the Maslow's Pyramid in Paralympics. Meanwhile, the base — the grassroots — still has much work to do. Satyanarayana Shimoga, a former middle-distance runner turned coach and administrator, has witnessed the seasonal changes in India's Paralympic journey.

"I've spent time in East Germany and Kenya; both are polar opposites in terms of societal advancement. But Kenya, without resources, would win medals, sometimes on par with

East Germany. That left me stumped. If they can do it, why can't India figure out a way to excel?" he says, adding that he had asked himself this question over a decade ago. The answer now lies in training athletes like H.N. Girisha and Mariyappan, among others, to reach the podium over the next three Paralympic cycles.

For Satyanarayana, the health of the ecosystem boils down to the health of the most rudimentary block of the system — sports in schools. But he is candidly critical of the first identifiers of talent: physical education teachers in schools.

"Our physical education teachers need to get active themselves," he says.

"Sports teachers are supposed to observe students and recognise their potential. But now, they're just martials. If someone misbehaves, they're there to punish or correct. This cannot be how the system functions," Satyanarayana laments.

With vast experience working in senior positions within the athletics ecosystem, both for able-bodied athletes and athletes with disabilities, the Bengaluru native identifies a major area of untapped potential in India: university sports.

"The World University Games is a huge international event, and it's a stepping stone for many athletes who go on to become world champions. India has never taken this tier of competition seriously; it's treated as a formality. During the formative years — school and university levels — the same 15 to 20 people circulate through multiple sports. It requires better planning and collaboration from all stakeholders."

All about attention

Satyanarayana hails Deepa's role, particularly as an eloquent communicator, in rebranding the

« Many of these athletes are no longer just seen as 'disabled' individuals, but as athletes competing in disability sports because their excellence is the binding factor – Nandan Kamath, co-founder GoSports Foundation »